

jQueryUI is one plug-in that has a set of components for developing rich client user interfaces. Themeroles [jqueryui.com/themeroller] allows us to design custom jQuery UI themes. Some of the other plug-ins can be found at plugins.jquery.com.

Now, coming back to the subject of this article, it's jQuery and jQuery UI that will help us develop much more interesting and interactive Web pages easily. There's obviously a reason why Google, Digg, Technorati, Mozilla, Wordpress, Drupal and many others use jQuery extensively.

Let's try an example

In order to use jQuery, you need to download it from www.jquery.com. There are two versions of jQuery available: the development and the production version. The production version is compressed and much smaller in size. However, for a trial, any version should do the job. Let us quickly build an HTML table with zebra stripes (which is nothing but a table with alternate rows being presented with different background colours). Apart from zebra stripes, the rows have to be highlighted when the mouse hovers over it. Figure 1 illustrates the example.

For zebra stripes, you need to decide on colours for the table header, odd rows, even rows and the colour you want to use during the mouse-hover. In this example, we have chosen orange for the table header background, white for the odd numbered rows, light blue for even numbered rows and pale green to highlight the rows on mouse hover. The following are the styles used:

```
<style type="text/css">
  th {
    background: orange;
    font-weight: bold;
  }

  td {
    background: white;
  }

  tr.alt td {
    background: palegreen;
  }
</style>
```

By the way, these styles are not a requirement from jQuery alone—you'll need these even when working with any other framework.

The next step is to use jQuery and create the zebra stripes. The following is the code that you need to write to implement the stripes in the table:

```
<script src="jquery-prod.js"></script>
```

```
<script type="text/javascript">
$(document).ready(function() {
  //jQuery ready is quicker than onload
  $(function(){
    $(".tr").mouseover(function() { $(this).addClass("over");});
  });
  $(".tr").mouseout(function() {
    $(this).removeClass("over");
  });
  $(".tr.even").mouseover(function() { $(this).addClass("over");});
  $(".tr.even").mouseout(function() {
    $(this).removeClass("over");
  });
});
</script>
```

As you can see, you first have to include the jQuery library, which is distributed as a single JavaScript file. We have downloaded it from the jQuery website and renamed it 'jquery-prod.js'. The next script tag contains JavaScript code that uses jQuery functions—**ready**, **mouseover**, **addClass**, **mouseout** and **removeClass**. Also, this is going to work on the HTML tag with the class attribute set to **lfr**.

Let us analyse how the functionalities are achieved. During a page load, jQuery registers the function that needs to be invoked during "mouseover" and "mouseout". For example, when the mouse is moved over "tr", a class attribute "over" is added and when the mouse is moved out, the class attribute is removed. Also, the class attribute of even rows is set to "alt". With these few lines of code, the zebra stripes are ready.

jQuery features

There are many things you need to do to make the Web page interactive with JavaScript. We may need to access a part of the page and modify specific contents, contact the Web server using AJAX and get the data from the server on-demand, change the look and feel of the Web page, manipulate DOM, animate the page, and handle browser events. All this is supported and is relatively easier to do with jQuery. For example, with a few lines of JavaScript, you can implement zebra striped HTML tables with ease. The design and architecture of jQuery is extensible and this is the main reason why jQuery is simple and powerful.

In this article, we looked at some common challenges in using JavaScript and how JavaScript libraries can help overcome them. We also explored how to integrate jQuery with existing Web pages. We hope this article gave you some idea about jQuery. In the coming months, we will discuss more about jQuery and its features. Happy coding! 

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